



**Above** A heaped bowl of *curanto*, demonstrating what a feast this is – slow-baked seafoods, meats, vegetables, and dumplings are piled high

**Left** The seemingly precarious but long-standing *palafitos*, or stilt houses, rise up from the water all over Chiloé, but most impressively in Castro



**Above** *Curanto* is cooked in an earthen pit; the food is protected from the fire-heated stones and sod layers between enormous *nalca* leaves

## Festival Costumbrista

The Festival Costumbrista Chilote is Chiloé's biggest annual festival and a vibrant celebration of its island culture. It takes place at locations across the archipelago in January and February. Festival-goers take part in island activities including cooking *curanto* in traditional earthen pits (visitors take a hand in creating the pit and its food), as well as weaving, sheep-shearing, driving oxen, and making jelly. Food stands serve *curanto* and archipelago staples such as shellfish *empanadas* (savory pastry turnovers), *licor de oro* (a fermented cow-milk liqueur), and ulmo honey – a sweet honey made from the native ulmo tree.

## The Best Places to Eat Curanto

### Restaurant Octavio moderate

The setting for this restaurant is an old fisherman's house overlooking the glassy waters of the Castro Fjord. Built from native island wood, the house stands on tall stilts in the fjord's frigid waters and has an exterior painted in bright primary colors. On the inside, it is total rusticity and warmth. A wooden entrance door creaks inward, floorboards groan underfoot and, at the heart of the restaurant floor, an open fire crackles and roars. Choose a window table for its magical views across the Castro Fjord to mist-shrouded, forest-swathed mountains on the opposite shore.

The menu at Octavio brims with Chiloé specialties. Choose the *cochayuyo* (seaweed) soup appetizer and *curanto* main course. Prepared *a la olla*, in a cauldron, your *curanto* arrives steaming with clams and mussels plucked from the ocean at daybreak, and piled high with sausages and more. Servings are huge – you'll probably only need one portion to feed two. Round off your meal with Octavio's celestial papaya-fruit-and-cream dessert.

**Avenida Pedro Montt 261, Castro; open noon–midnight daily; +56 65 632 855**

### Also in Chiloé

In Ancud, **Restaurant Kuranton (+56 65 623 090; moderate)** faces the sea and serves an inspired *curanto*. It has a snug ambience, with low ceilings and tangerine walls that are hung with carvings and aged artwork. All across the archipelago, colorful, family-run restaurants at fishermen's markets serve first-rate, and very cheap, *curanto*. **Ballena Sur (+56 99 414 354; inexpensive)**, over the waterfront and inside the market at Chonchi, is one of the very best, with beautiful views of Chonchi Bay. In Curaco de Vélez, on Isla de Quichao, **Restaurant Los Troncos (no telephone; inexpensive)** is a delight. A rustic garden restaurant with ocean vistas, it serves *curanto*, fresh salmon, and the house specialty: salty oysters, eaten raw with a hunk of lemon.

### Also in Chile

On the mainland, Chiloé's gateway city, Puerto Montt, shares the *curanto* tradition. At its raucous Angelmó Fish Market, climb wooden stairs to **La Estrella de Angelmó (no telephone; inexpensive)**, which serves the dish amid a mind-boggling variety of ultra-fresh seafood specials, from stewed crabs to sea urchins. In the capital city, Santiago, **Restaurant El Galeón (www.elgaleon.cl; moderate)** is a seafood restaurant located within the capital's atmospheric Mercado Central (Central Market). It has dished up a fantastic *curanto* since 1935.